



The Volga

The longest river in Europe and the core of its biggest river system, regarded as Russia's national waterway

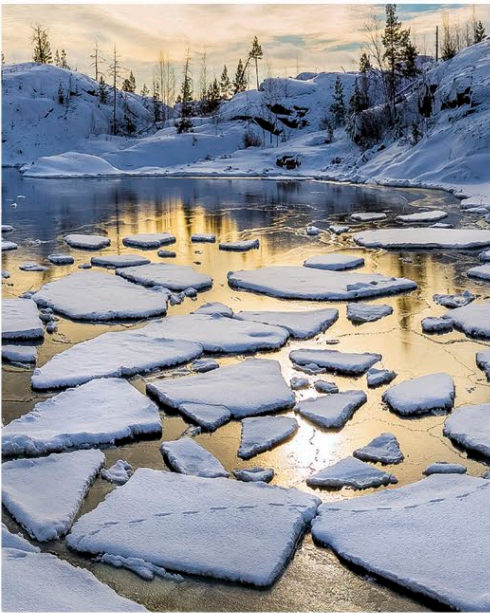
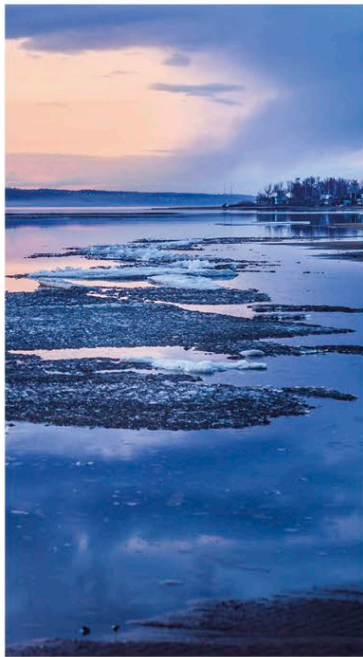


The Volga is Europe's longest river, at the heart of the continent's largest river system. Rising in the Valdai Hills, northwest of Moscow, it flows 2,293 miles (3,690km) southeastward through western Russia before emptying into the Caspian Sea. The lush Volga Delta, which spans 100 miles (160km), is the largest river estuary in Europe. With a catchment area extending eastward to the Ural Mountains, the Volga drains most of European Russia. Along its course, it collects more than 200 tributaries, and its watershed contains 11 major cities. The river is traditionally referred to by Russians as Mother Volga.



△ THICK BILL
The largest species of tern, the Caspian tern is a common sight in the Volga Delta. This species has a distinctly chunkier bill than other terns.

▷ ICE FLOES
The Volga is affected by ice over much of its length for about 100 days each year.

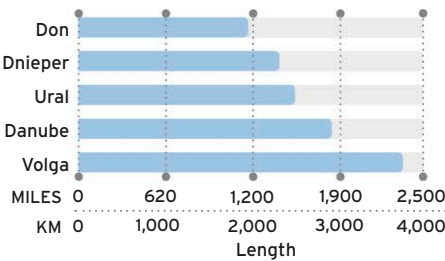


△ FROZEN INLET
The edges and inlets of the lake start to freeze in December, and by the end of February the entire surface of the lake is frozen over.



EUROPE'S LONGEST RIVERS

Four of the five longest rivers in Europe pass through Russia at some part of their course, and the Volga and the Don are contained within its borders. The Danube crosses 10 different countries on its course.



△ GREEN DELTA
The Volga brings life to an otherwise arid landscape as it flows into the saline Caspian Sea, the world's largest inland body of water.